

Cyprian 251

De catholicae ecclesiae unitate, cc. 4–5 — the one chair (A.D. 251; CSEL 3.1, pp. 212–214)

4. If anyone considers and examines these things, there is no need of a long treatise and of arguments. The proof is easy for faith in a compendium of the truth. The Lord speaks to Peter: *I say to thee, that thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build my Church, and the gates of hell shall not overcome it. And I will give to thee the keys of the kingdom of heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt bind upon earth shall be bound also in heaven, and whatsoever thou shalt loose upon earth shall be loosed also in heaven.* Upon one he builds the Church; and although after his resurrection he assigns an equal power to all the apostles and says: *As the Father hath sent me, I also send you. Receive ye the Holy Spirit: if you shall forgive the sins of any, they shall be forgiven him; if you shall retain the sins of any, they shall be retained,* yet, that he might make the unity manifest, he by his own authority so disposed the origin of that same unity as to begin from one. Assuredly the rest of the apostles too were that which Peter was, endowed with an equal partnership both of honour and of power; but the beginning proceeds from unity, that the Church of Christ may be shown to be one. This one Church the Holy Spirit likewise designates in the Song of Songs in the person of the Lord, and says: *One is my dove, my perfect one; she is the only one of her mother, the chosen of her that bore her.* Does he who does not hold this unity of the Church believe that he holds the faith? Does he who strives against and resists the Church trust that he is in the Church? — when the blessed apostle Paul also teaches this same thing and sets forth the sacrament of unity, saying: *One body and one Spirit, one hope of your calling, one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God.*

5. This unity we ought firmly to hold and to vindicate, especially we bishops who preside in the Church, that we may prove the episcopate itself also to be one and undivided. Let no one deceive the brotherhood by a lie, let no one corrupt the faith of the truth by a faithless prevarication. The episcopate is one, of which a part is held by each for the whole. The Church is one, which is extended more widely into a multitude by the increase of fruitfulness — just as the rays of the sun are many but the light is one, and the branches of a tree are many but the strength is one, founded upon a tenacious root, and when many streams flow down from one spring, though a multiplicity seems to be diffused by the abundance of the overflowing supply, yet the unity is preserved in the origin. Pluck a ray from the body of the sun: its unity does not admit a division of the light; break a branch from a tree: once broken, it cannot bud; cut off a stream from its source: cut off, it dries up. So too the Church of the Lord, suffused with light, extends its rays over the whole world; yet the light is one which is diffused everywhere, and the unity of the body is not separated. She stretches out her branches over the whole earth in the abundance of her plenty, she spreads her flowing streams more widely; yet the head is one, and the origin one, and one the mother copious in the successions of her fruitfulness. Of her womb are we born, by her milk are we nourished, by her spirit are we animated.

Ep. 43, § 1 — Cyprian's own seat: your suffrage and the judgment of God (A.D. 251; CSEL 3.2, pp. 590–591)

Although, dearest brethren, Virtius, a most faithful and most upright presbyter, and likewise Rogatianus and Numidicus, presbyters, confessors and illustrious in the glory of the divine favour, and also the deacons, good men and devoted with every service to the ecclesiastical administration, together with the other ministries afford you the full diligence of their presence, and do not cease by assiduous exhortations to strengthen individuals, and also to govern and reform the minds of the lapsed with salutary counsels, — nevertheless I too, as much as I can, admonish, and as I can, I visit you by my letters. By letters, I say, dearest brethren. For the malice and perfidy of certain presbyters brought it about that it was not permitted me to come to you before the day of Pascha, while, mindful of their conspiracy and retaining those old poisons against my episcopate — nay, against your suffrage and the judgment of God — they renew their former assault against us and again refurbish with their accustomed snares their sacrilegious machinations. And indeed, by the providence of God — this being neither our will nor our wish, nay, while we both pardoned and kept silence — they paid the penalties they had deserved: so that, not cast out by us, they cast themselves out of their own accord, and passed sentence upon themselves according to their own conscience, and, conspirators and criminals, by your divine suffrages expelled themselves of their own will from the Church.

Ep. 43, § 5 — one God, one Christ, one Church, one chair (pp. 593–595)

God cries out and says: *Do not hear the words of the false prophets, for the visions of their heart deceive them. They speak, but not from the mouth of the Lord. They say to those who cast away the word of the Lord: Peace shall be to you.* They now offer peace who themselves do not have peace; and they who have withdrawn from the Church do not permit the lapsed to be led back and recalled to the Church. God is one, and Christ is one, and the Church is one, and the chair is one, founded upon Peter by the Lord's word. Another altar cannot be set up, nor a new priesthood be made, besides the one altar and the one priesthood. Whoever gathers elsewhere scatters. Whatever is instituted by human madness so that the divine ordinance is violated is adulterous, impious, sacrilegious. Depart far from the contagion of men of this kind, and by fleeing avoid their words like a cancer and a plague, the Lord forewarning and saying: *They are blind leaders of the blind. But the blind man leading the blind, both shall fall into the ditch.* They stand in the way of our prayers, which you pour out with us day and night to God, that you may appease him by just satisfaction. They stand in the way of our tears, by which you wash away the guilt of the sin committed. They stand in the way of the peace which you truly and faithfully beg from the mercy of the Lord — not knowing that it is written: *And that prophet, or that dreamer of a dream, he who has spoken to make you err from the Lord your God.* Let no one, brethren, make you err from the ways of the Lord. Let no one carry you Christians away from the gospel of Christ, let no one take away the sons of the Church from the Church. Let them perish alone to themselves who have wished to perish; let them remain outside the Church alone who have withdrawn from the Church; let them alone not be with the bishops who have rebelled against the bishops; let them alone undergo the penalties of their conspiracy who — once, according to your suffrages, now, according to the judgments of God — have deserved to undergo the sentence of their own conspiracy and malignity.

Ep. 44, complete — Novatian's envoys refused; the axiom (A.D. 251; pp. 597–599)

1. There came to us, dearest brother, sent by Novatian, Maximus a presbyter, and Augendus a deacon, and a certain Machaeus, and Longinus. But indeed, when from the letters which they carried with them, and from their speech and asseveration, we had learned that Novatian had been made bishop, moved by the wickedness of an ordination unlawful and made against the catholic Church, we judged that they must at once be restrained from communion with us. And when, for the time being, the things which they were obstinately and pertinaciously attempting to assert had been refuted and beaten back, nevertheless I and very many colleagues who had assembled to me awaited the arrival of our colleagues Caldonius and Fortunatus, whom we had lately sent as legates to you and to our fellow-bishops who had been present at your ordination, so that, upon their arrival and their reporting back the truth of what had been done, the wickedness of the opposing party might be broken by a greater authority and by a lucid proof through them. But there arrived Pompeius and Stephanus, our colleagues, who themselves also, in order to inform us from thence, brought forward clear indications and testimonies according to their gravity and good faith, so that there was no need that those who had come sent by Novatian should be heard any further.

2. And when in the assembly they were bursting forth with invidious revilings and turbulent clamours, and were demanding that the charges which they said they brought and could prove should be examined publicly by us and by the people, we denied that it accorded with our gravity that we should suffer the honour of our colleague — already chosen and ordained and approved by the laudable verdict of many — to be tossed about further by the slanderous voice of rivals. And because it would be too long to heap up in a letter the arguments by which they were refuted and crushed and stripped bare of having wrought a heresy by unlawful attempts, you will hear each particular most fully from Primitivus our fellow-presbyter when he shall come to you.

3. And lest their raging audacity should ever cease, here too they strive to tear apart the members of Christ into the parties of schism, and to cut up and mangle the one body of the catholic Church, so that, running about from door to door through the houses of many, or from town to town through certain cities, they may seek for themselves companions of their obstinacy and of their split error. To whom we once gave answer, and do not cease to charge them, that, laying aside their pernicious dissension and contention, they should know that it is impiety to desert their mother, and should acknowledge and understand that, when a bishop has once been made and approved by the testimony and judgment of the colleagues and of the people, another can in no way be constituted; so that, if they profess that they have peaceably and faithfully taken counsel for themselves, if they profess that they are champions of the gospel and of Christ, let them first return to the Church. I desire you, dearest brother, ever to fare well.

Ep. 45, § 1 — recognition through legates and letters (pp. 599–600)

As befitted the servants of God, and especially priests just and peace-loving, dearest brother, we had lately sent our colleagues Caldonius and Fortunatus, that they might strive and labour, as much as they could, not only by the persuasion of our letters, but by their own presence and by the counsel of all of you, to compose the members of the split body into the unity of the catholic Church, and to bind together the bond of Christian

charity. But since the obstinate and inflexible stubbornness of the opposing party not only refused the bosom and embrace of the root and the mother, but even, with discord swelling and breaking out for the worse, set up a bishop for itself, and, against the sacrament once handed down of the divine dispensation and of catholic unity, made an adulterous and contrary head outside the Church, — having received the letters both of you and of our colleagues, and likewise with the arrival of good men and our most dear colleagues Pompeius and Stephanus, by whom all these things were affirmed to us firmly and proven with common rejoicing, we directed our letter to you, according to what the sanctity and truth alike of divine tradition and of ecclesiastical institution required. And, moreover, conveying these same matters to the notice of our individual colleagues throughout our province, we directed that from these too brethren should be sent with letters.

Ep. 48, complete — Africa's collective recognition of Cornelius (pp. 606–608)

1. I have read your letter, dearest brother, which you sent by Primitivus our fellow-presbyter, in which I have learned that you were disturbed because, when a letter had been directed to you in the name of Polycarp from the colony of Hadrumentum, after we — I and Liberalis — had come to that same place, letters began to be directed thither to the presbyters and to the deacons.

2. We wish you to know this, and for certain to believe that it was done by no fickleness or affront. But when we, several colleagues who had met together, had determined that, our fellow-bishops Caldonius and Fortunatus having been sent as legates to you, all things should for the time being remain untouched in suspense, until those same colleagues of ours should return to us, matters there being either brought to peace or ascertained according to the truth, — the presbyters and deacons residing at Hadrumentum, their fellow-bishop Polycarp being absent, did not know what had been agreed among us in common. But when we came in person, our decision having been ascertained, they too began to observe that which the rest also did, so that in nothing did the agreement of the churches situated there differ.

3. Yet certain persons sometimes disturb minds and spirits by their talk, when they announce some things otherwise than the truth stands. For we, in giving a reason to individuals setting sail, that they might not sail with any stumbling-block, know that we exhorted them to acknowledge and to hold the mother and root of the catholic Church. But since our province is more widely spread — it has also Numidia and Mauretania cohering to it — lest a schism made in the City should confound the minds of the absent with uncertain opinion, it was resolved that, the truth of the matter having been ascertained by us through the bishops, and a greater authority having been established for approving your ordination, then at length, every scruple having been shaken out from the hearts of individuals, letters should be made through all without exception situated there — as indeed they are being made — that all our colleagues might approve and firmly hold both you and your communion, that is, the unity of the catholic Church, together with charity. And we rejoice that this has come about divinely, and that our counsel has providently gone forward.

4. For so now both the truth and the dignity of your episcopate have been established by clearest light, by most manifest and most firm approbation, that from the rescripts of our colleagues who wrote letters to us from thence, and from the report and testimonies of our fellow-bishops Pompeius and Stephanus and Caldonius and Fortunatus, both the

necessary origin of your ordination and its just ground, and also its glorious innocence, might be known to all. And that we may administer this steadfastly and firmly together with our other colleagues also, and may hold it in the concordant unanimity of the catholic Church, the divine protection will bring it to pass, so that the Lord, who deigns to choose and to constitute priests for himself in his Church, may also protect those chosen and constituted, by his own will and help, — governingly inspiring and supplying both vigour for curbing the contumacy of the wicked and gentleness for fostering the penitence of the lapsed. I desire you, dearest brother, ever to fare well.

Ep. 49, complete — Cornelius to Cyprian: the confessors return (pp. 608–612)

1. As great a solicitude and anxiety as we sustained concerning those confessors who, by the guile and malice of a crafty and veteran man, had been circumvented and almost deceived and estranged from the Church, with as great a joy have we been affected, and we give thanks to Almighty God and to Christ our Lord, since — their error being recognized and the venomous cunning of the malignant man, as of a serpent, being understood — they came, of a simple will, back to the Church whence they had gone out, as they themselves profess from their heart. And at first indeed our brethren, of approved faith, loving peace, desiring unity, reported the swelling of those men and the softening of these; yet the assurance was not sufficient for it to be readily granted to us to believe that they had suddenly been changed. But afterwards Urbanus and Sidonius, confessors, came to our fellow-presbyters, affirming that Maximus, a confessor and presbyter, ** desired, equally with them, to return into the Church. But since many things had preceded, marked out by them — which you too learned from our fellow-bishops and from my letters — so that credit might not rashly be given to them, it was resolved that from their own mouth and confession those things should be heard which they had charged by their embassy. And when they had come, and the things they had done were being demanded of them by the presbyters, last of all — because throughout all the churches frequent letters full of calumnies and revilings had been sent in their name and had thrown almost all the churches into confusion — they affirmed that they had been circumvented, and that they had not known what was contained in those letters, but had only subscribed; that, led about by his craft, they had also committed themselves to schism and had been authors of heresy, so as to allow a hand to be laid on him as if unto the episcopate. And when these and other things had been reproached to them, they besought that they might be abolished and taken away from memory.

2. The whole transaction having been reported to me, it was resolved that the presbytery should be convened. There were present also five bishops, who were present on that very day, so that, our counsel being confirmed, what ought to be observed concerning their persons might be determined by the consent of all. And that you might discern the movement of all and the counsel of each, it was resolved that our sentences too should be brought to your notice, which you will also read appended below. These things being thus done, there came into the presbytery Maximus, Urbanus, Sidonius, and very many brethren who had joined themselves to them, desiring with the utmost entreaties that the things which had been done before should pass into oblivion, and that no mention of them should be made — just as if nothing had been either committed or said — and that, all things being mutually remitted, they might now present a clean and pure heart to God, following the gospel word: *that they are blessed who are pure in heart, for they shall see God*. As was fitting, this whole transaction had to be intimated to the people, that they might see those very men established in the Church whom they had for so long seen erring and wandering, and had grieved over. Their will being known, a great concourse of

the brotherhood took place. There was one voice of all, giving thanks to God, expressing the joy of their heart with tears, embracing them as if on this day they had been freed from the punishment of prison. And, to set down their own words: ‘We,’ they say, ‘know Cornelius to be bishop of the most holy catholic Church, chosen by Almighty God and by Christ our Lord. We confess our error. We have suffered an imposture. We were circumvented by perfidy and captious loquacity. For although we seemed to have had, as it were, a certain communion with a schismatic and heretical man, yet our heart was always in the Church. For we are not ignorant that there is one God, and that there is one Christ the Lord whom we have confessed, one Holy Spirit, and that there ought to be one bishop in the catholic Church.’ By this profession of theirs, who would not be moved, that what they had confessed before the power of the world they should ratify, established in the Church? Wherefore we bade Maximus the presbyter to acknowledge his place. As for the rest, with the immense suffrage of the people, we remitted all that had been done before to Almighty God, in whose power all things are kept in reserve.

3. These things, therefore, dearest brother, at the same hour, at the same moment, we have transmitted to you in writing; and I at once sent off Nicephorus the acolyte, hastening to go down to sail, from the assembly to you, so that, with no procrastination, you might, as if present in this clergy and in this gathering of the people, give thanks together with us to Almighty God and to Christ our Lord. We believe it will come to pass — nay rather we are now confident for certain — that the others too, who are established in this error, will shortly return into the Church, when they shall see their own authors acting with us. This letter, I think, you ought, dearest brother, to send also to the other churches, so that all may know that the guile and prevarication of this schismatic and heretic are day by day being emptied out. Fare well, dearest brother.

Ep. 55, §§ 8–9 — the fourfold constitution of Cornelius’s title (A.D. 251/2; pp. 629–631)

8. I come now, dearest brother, to the person of Cornelius our colleague, that you may know Cornelius more truly along with us — not from the lie of the malicious and the detractors, but from the judgment of God who made him bishop, and from the testimony of the fellow-bishops, the whole number of whom throughout the whole world consented with concordant unanimity. For as to that which commends our most dear Cornelius to God and to Christ and to his Church, and likewise to all his fellow-priests, by praiseworthy report: he did not come to the episcopate suddenly, but, promoted through all the ecclesiastical offices and having often deserved well of the Lord in the divine administrations, he ascended to the lofty summit of the priesthood through all the grades of religion. Then, further, he neither asked for the episcopate itself nor wished for it, nor did he seize it as the rest do whom the swelling of their arrogance and pride puffs up; but, quiet in other respects and modest, and such as those are wont to be who are divinely chosen to this place, out of the modesty of his virginal continence and out of the humility of a bashfulness innate in him and guarded, he did not, as some do, use force in order to be made bishop, but he himself suffered force so that, compelled, he should receive the episcopate. And he was made bishop by very many of our colleagues who were then present in the city of Rome, who sent to us letters honourable and laudable and illustrious by the testimony of their commendation concerning his ordination. And Cornelius was made bishop by the judgment of God and of his Christ, by the testimony of almost all the clergy, by the suffrage of the people who were then present, by the college of aged priests and of good men — when no one had been made before him, when the place of Fabian, that is, the place of Peter and the grade of the sacerdotal chair, was vacant: which being occupied, and confirmed by the will of God and by the consent of us all, whoever should

now wish to be made bishop must needs be made outside, nor can he have ecclesiastical ordination who does not hold the unity of the Church. Whoever he shall be, though vaunting much of himself and claiming very much for himself, he is profane, he is an alien, he is outside; and since after the first there cannot be a second, whoever is made after the one who alone ought to be is now not a second, but no one.

9. Then, further, after an episcopate neither canvassed for nor extorted, but received by the will of God who makes priests, how great, in his very received episcopate, was his virtue, how great the strength of his soul, of what kind the firmness of his faith — which we ought with a simple heart both thoroughly to perceive and to praise — that he sat undaunted at Rome in the sacerdotal chair at that time when a tyrant hostile to the priests of God was threatening things utterable and unutterable, when he would much more patiently and tolerably have heard that a rival prince was being raised up against himself than that a priest of God was being constituted at Rome. Is not he, dearest brother, to be proclaimed with the highest testimony of virtue and faith? Is he not to be reckoned among the glorious confessors and martyrs — he who sat so long a time awaiting the executioners of his body and the avengers of the raging tyrant, men who would either fall upon Cornelius with the sword, as he resisted the deadly edicts and trod down with the vigour of his faith the threats and the tortures and the torments, or crucify him, or roast him with fire, or with whatever unheard-of kind of punishments mangle his vitals and his limbs? Even though the majesty of the protecting Lord and his goodness also protected the priest, once made, whom he had willed to be made, nevertheless Cornelius, as far as pertains to his devotion and fear, suffered whatever he could suffer, and, first in his priesthood, conquered the tyrant who was afterwards conquered by arms and by war.

Ep. 55, § 21 — the bond of concord remaining (pp. 638–639)

And indeed, among our predecessors, certain of the bishops here in our province thought that peace ought not to be granted to adulterers, and closed off entirely against adulteries the place of penitence. Nevertheless they did not withdraw from the college of their fellow-bishops, nor break the unity of the catholic Church by the obstinacy of their harshness or of their censure, so that, because peace was being granted to adulterers by others, he who did not grant it should be separated from the Church. The bond of concord remaining, and the undivided sacrament of the catholic Church persevering, each bishop disposes and directs his own action, being about to render to the Lord the account of his purpose.

Ep. 55, § 24 — made by sixteen co-bishops; the rival an adulterer and outsider (pp. 642–643)

But as regards the person of Novatian, dearest brother, concerning whom you desired that it be written to you what heresy he had introduced: you should know that in the first place we ought not even to be curious about what he teaches, since he teaches outside. Whoever he is, and of whatever sort he is, he is not a Christian who is not in the Church of Christ. Though he vaunt himself and proclaim his philosophy or his eloquence with proud words, he who has held neither fraternal charity nor ecclesiastical unity has lost even that which he had before. Unless indeed he seems to you a bishop who — when a bishop had been made in the Church by sixteen fellow-bishops — strives, an adulterer and an outsider, to be made bishop by deserters through canvassing; and, whereas from

Christ there is one Church spread over the whole world into many members, and likewise one episcopate diffused in the concordant multitude of many bishops, he, after the tradition of God, after the connected and everywhere conjoined unity of the catholic Church, attempts to make a human church and sends his new apostles through very many cities, that he may set up certain recent foundations of his own institution; and although long ago, throughout all the provinces and through the several cities, bishops have been ordained, ancient in age, sound in faith, proved in pressure, proscribed in persecution, he dares to create other pseudo-bishops over them: as if he could either traverse the whole world by the obstinacy of a new endeavour, or rend the framework of the ecclesiastical body by the sowing of his discord — not knowing that schismatics always burn hot in their beginnings, but cannot have increase, nor augment what they have unlawfully begun, but straightway fail together with their depraved rivalry. But he could not hold the episcopate, even if, having first been made a bishop, he should cut himself off from the body of his fellow-bishops and from the unity of the Church, since the apostle admonishes that we should mutually bear with one another, lest we withdraw from the unity which God has constituted, and says: *bearing with one another in love, being diligent to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace*. Whoever, therefore, observes neither the unity of the Spirit nor the bond of peace, and separates himself from the bond of the Church and from the college of the priests, can have neither the power nor the honour of a bishop — he who has willed to hold neither the unity nor the peace of the episcopate.

Ep. 59, §§ 5–6 — after the suffrage and consent no one may make himself judge; chosen in peace (A.D. 252; pp. 671–674)

5. Since so many and such great examples precede, by which the sacerdotal authority and power is confirmed by the divine favour, what do you think are those who, enemies of the priests and rebels against the catholic Church, are terrified neither by the threatening of the forewarning Lord nor by the vengeance of the future judgment? For heresies have not arisen, nor have schisms been born, from any other source than when the priest of God is not obeyed, and there is not thought to be in the Church one priest for the time and one judge for the time in the stead of Christ; to whom, if the whole brotherhood would render obedience according to the divine teachings, no one would stir up anything against the college of the priests, no one after the divine judgment, after the suffrage of the people, after the consent of the fellow-bishops, would make himself a judge — now not of the bishops but of God; no one would rend the Church of Christ by breaking its unity; no one, pleasing himself and swelling with pride, would found a new heresy apart and outside: unless there be someone of such sacrilegious rashness and of a lost mind as to think that a priest is made without the judgment of God, when the Lord says in his gospel: *Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing, and not one of them falls to the ground without the Father's will?* When he says that not even the least things happen without the will of God, does anyone suppose that things highest and great happen in the Church of God, either without God knowing or without his permitting, and that priests, that is his stewards, are ordained not by his decision? This is not to have the faith by which we live; this is not to give honour to God, by whose beck and decision we know and believe that all things are ruled and governed. Plainly, they are not made bishops by the will of God — those who are made outside the Church, those who are made against the ordinance and tradition of the gospel — as the Lord himself sets down and says in the twelve prophets: *They have set up a king for themselves, and not through me*. And again: *Their sacrifices are as the bread of mourning; all who eat them shall be defiled*. And through Isaiah too

the Holy Spirit cries out and says: *Woe to you, apostate sons. Thus says the Lord: you have taken counsel, not through me; and you have made a covenant, not through my spirit, to add sins upon sins.*

6. But — for I speak provoked, I speak grieving, I speak compelled — when a bishop is substituted in the place of one deceased, when he is chosen in peace by the suffrage of the whole people, when he is protected by the help of God in persecution, faithfully joined to all his colleagues, already proved to his flock in the episcopate for a quadrennium, in quiet serving discipline, in tempest proscribed, with the name of his episcopate applied and attached to him, so often demanded for the lion, honoured in the circus, in the amphitheatre, by the testimony of the Lord's favour — in these very days too, in which I wrote this letter to you, because of the sacrifices which by a proposed edict the people were bidden to celebrate, again demanded for the lion by the shout of the populace in the circus: when such a man, dearest brother, seems to be assailed by certain desperate and lost men established outside the Church, it is apparent who assails him — not Christ, of course, who either constitutes or protects the priests, but he who, the adversary of Christ and the enemy of his Church, persecutes with his own molestation the prelate set over the Church, so that, the pilot being removed, he may rage more atrociously and more violently amid the shipwrecks of the Church.

Ep. 59, § 14 — the chair of Peter and the principal Church (pp. 683–684)

For whom it was not even enough to have withdrawn from the gospel, to have taken away from the lapsed the hope of satisfaction and of penitence, to have removed those enwrapped in frauds, or stained with adulteries, or polluted by the deadly contagion of the sacrifices, from all sense and fruit of penitence — that they should not entreat God, nor make in the Church the confession of their crimes — to have set up for themselves outside the Church and against the Church a conventicle of a lost faction, whither might flow together a crowd of those conscious of guilt to themselves and unwilling to entreat God and to make satisfaction: after these things, still, moreover, a pseudo-bishop having been set up for them by heretics, they dare to sail off and to carry letters, from schismatics and profane persons, to the chair of Peter and to the principal Church, whence the sacerdotal unity took its rise — and not to consider that these are the Romans whose faith was praised with the apostle proclaiming it, to whom perfidy can have no access. But what is the reason for coming, and for announcing a pseudo-bishop made against the bishops? For either what they have done pleases them and they persevere in their crime; or, if it displeases them and they withdraw, they know whither they should return. For, since it has been ordained by us all, and is alike equitable and just, that each man's case be heard there where the crime was committed, and to the several pastors a portion of the flock has been assigned which each is to rule and govern, being about to render to the Lord an account of his own action, it certainly behooves those over whom we are set not to run about, nor to dash apart by their crafty and deceitful rashness the cohering concord of the bishops, but to plead their cause there where they can have both accusers and witnesses of their crime: unless to a few desperate and lost men the authority of the bishops established in Africa seems to be too little — they who have already judged concerning them, and lately, by the gravity of their judgment, condemned their conscience, bound with many snares of their misdeeds. Their case has now been examined, sentence has now been pronounced concerning them; nor does it befit the censure of the priests to be censured by the levity of a fickle and inconstant mind, since the Lord teaches and says: *Let your speech be, yea, yea; nay, nay.*

Ep. 66, § 8 — the bishop in the Church and the Church in the bishop (pp. 732–733)

You have also written that the Church now, on my account, has a portion of itself in dispersion — whereas the whole people of the Church is both gathered and made one and joined to itself in undivided concord, and those alone have remained outside who, even if they were within, would have had to be cast out; nor does the Lord, the protector and guardian of his people, suffer the wheat to be torn away from his threshing-floor, but only the chaff can be separated from the Church — since the apostle also says: *For what if some of them have fallen away from the faith? Has their unbelief made void the faith of God? God forbid. For God is truthful, but every man a liar*; and the Lord too, in the gospel, when the disciples were abandoning him as he spoke, turning to the twelve, said: *Do you also wish to go?* Peter answered him, saying: *Lord, to whom shall we go? Thou hast the word of eternal life, and we have believed and known that thou art the Son of the living God.* There Peter speaks, upon whom the Church had been built, teaching and showing in the name of the Church that, even though a contumacious and proud multitude of those unwilling to obey should depart, yet the Church does not depart from Christ; and they are the Church — a people united to its priest, and a flock adhering to its shepherd. Whence you ought to know that the bishop is in the Church and the Church in the bishop, and that if anyone is not with the bishop he is not in the Church; and that those flatter themselves in vain who, not having peace with the priests of God, creep in and believe that they secretly communicate with certain persons — since the Church, which is catholic and one, is not split nor divided, but is assuredly connected and bound together by the glue of the priests cohering mutually with one another.

Ep. 67, § 3 — the people's part in a just ordination (A.D. 254; pp. 737–738)

Nor let the people flatter itself, as if it could be immune from the contagion of the offence when communicating with a sinful priest and lending its consent to the unjust and unlawful episcopate of its prelate — since through the prophet Hosea the divine censure threatens and says: *Their sacrifices are as the bread of mourning; all who eat them shall be defiled*, teaching, that is, and showing that absolutely all are bound over to sin, whoever have been defiled by the sacrifice of a profane and unjust priest. This same thing we find made manifest in Numbers, when Korah and Dathan and Abiram claimed for themselves against Aaron the priest the licence of sacrificing. There too, through Moses, the Lord commands that the people be separated from them, lest, being joined to the wicked, one be involved also in the same wickedness. *Separate yourselves*, he says, *from the tents of most hardened, unjust men, and do not touch any of the things that are theirs, lest you perish together in their sin.* On which account the people, obeying the divine precepts and fearing God, ought to separate itself from a sinful prelate, and not to mingle itself with the sacrifices of a sacrilegious priest — since it especially has the power both of choosing worthy priests and of refusing the unworthy.

Ep. 67, § 5 — Sabinus ordained in the place of Basilides (pp. 739–740)

On which account it is to be diligently kept and held, from the divine tradition and the apostolic observance, that which among us too, and almost throughout all the provinces, is maintained: namely, that, for celebrating ordinations rightly, to that people for which a prelate is being ordained the nearest bishops of the same province should assemble, and the bishop be chosen with the people present, which knows most fully the life of each and has perceived the conduct of each from his manner of living. And this we see done also among you in the ordination of Sabinus our colleague — that by the suffrage of the whole brotherhood, and by the judgment of the bishops who had assembled in person and who had made letters to you concerning him, the episcopate was conferred upon him, and a hand was laid upon him in the place of Basilides. Nor can an ordination lawfully perfected be rescinded because Basilides, after his crimes had been detected and his conscience laid bare even by his own confession, going to Rome, deceived Stephen our colleague, who was situated far off and ignorant of the deed done and of the truth, so that he canvassed to be unjustly restored to the episcopate from which he had been justly deposed. This tends to this: that the offences of Basilides are not so much abolished as heaped up, so that to his former sins there has been added also the crime of falsehood and of circumvention. For not so much is he to be blamed to whom the deception was negligently made, as this man to be execrated who fraudulently deceived. But if Basilides could deceive men, he cannot deceive God, since it is written: *God is not mocked*. But neither could the deception avail Martialis, so that he too, involved in grave offences, ought not to hold the episcopate, since the apostle also admonishes and says: *A bishop must be without crime, as the steward of God*.

Ep. 68, complete — Marcian of Arles: the removal mechanism (A.D. 254/5; pp. 744–749)

1. Faustinus our colleague, residing at Lyons, dearest brother, has written to me once and again, signifying those things which I know were certainly announced also to you, both by him and by the rest of our fellow-bishops established in the same province: namely, that Marcianus, residing at Arles, has joined himself to Novatian, and has departed from the truth of the catholic Church and from the agreement of our body and of the priesthood, holding the most hardened depravity of the heretical presumption, so that to the servants of God — penitent and grieving and knocking at the Church with tears and groaning and sorrow — the consolations and helps of the divine mercy and of the paternal gentleness are closed off, and the wounded are not admitted to have their wounds fostered, but, left without hope of peace and communion, are cast forth to the rapine of the wolves and the prey of the devil. It is our part to take counsel and to bring aid for this matter, dearest brother — we who, considering the divine clemency and holding the balance for governing the Church, so exhibit the censure of vigour to sinners that nevertheless we do not deny the medicine of the divine goodness and mercy for raising up the lapsed and healing the wounded.

2. Wherefore you ought to write most full letters to our fellow-bishops established in Gaul, that they should no longer allow Marcianus — obstinate and proud, and an enemy of the divine mercy and of fraternal salvation — to insult our college, seeing that he does not yet seem to have been excommunicated by us, though he has long been boasting and proclaiming that, adhering to Novatian and following his obstinacy, he has separated himself from our communion; whereas Novatian himself, whom he follows, has long ago

been excommunicated and judged an enemy of the Church, and, when he had sent legates to us into Africa desiring to be admitted to our communion, carried back from hence, from a council of very many priests who were present, the sentence that he had begun to be outside, and that he could be communicated with by none of us — he who attempted to erect a profane altar, and to set up an adulterous chair, and to offer sacrilegious sacrifices against the true priest, against the bishop Cornelius, ordained in the catholic Church by the judgment of God and by the suffrage of the clergy and of the people; so that, if he should be willing to come to his senses and to return to the counsel of a sound mind, he should do penance and return a suppliant to the Church. How idle it is, dearest brother, that, Novatian having lately been beaten back and refuted and excommunicated by the priests of God throughout the whole world, we should now suffer his flatterers still to mock us and to pass judgment on the majesty and dignity of the Church.

3. Let letters be directed by you into the province and to the people residing at Arles, by which, Marcianus being excommunicated, another may be substituted in his place, and the flock of Christ, which to this day is despised, scattered and wounded by him, may be gathered together. Let it suffice that many there of our brethren in these past years have departed without peace. Or let aid be brought to the rest who survive, and who groan day and night, and, entreating the divine and paternal mercy, demand the consolation of our help. For therefore, dearest brother, the body of the priests is copious, bound together by the glue of mutual concord and by the bond of unity, so that, if any of our college should attempt to make a heresy and to lacerate and lay waste the flock of Christ, the rest may bring aid, and, as useful and merciful shepherds, may gather the Lord's sheep into the flock. For what if some harbour at sea, its defences broken, should begin to be dangerous and perilous to ships — do not those sailing direct their ships to other, near harbours, where there may be a safe [access] and a salutary entrance and a secure anchorage? Or if some inn on the road should begin to be beset and held by robbers, so that whoever enters is captured by the molestation of those lying in wait there — do not travellers, this having become known by report, seek out other, safer inns on their journey, where there may be trusty lodgings and shelters safe for travellers? This it is necessary should be the case among us, dearest brother: that we receive to us, with prompt and kind humanity, our brethren who, avoiding the rocks of Marcianus, seek the salutary harbours of the Church, and that we furnish to travellers such an inn as is in the gospel, in which those wounded and injured by robbers may be able to be received and fostered and protected by the innkeeper.

4. For what greater or better care of prelates is there than to provide, with diligent solicitude and salutary remedy, for the fostering and preserving of the sheep, since the Lord speaks and says: *What was made weak you have not strengthened, and what was sick you have not made strong, and what was afflicted you have not consoled, and what went astray you have not called back, and what perished you have not sought out: and my sheep have been scattered, because there are no shepherds, and they have become food for all the beasts of the field, and there was none who sought or who called back. Therefore thus says the Lord: Behold, I am against the shepherds, and I will require my sheep at their hands, and I will turn them away that they may not feed my sheep: and they shall feed them no more, and I will pluck them out of their mouth, and I will feed them with judgment.* Since, then, the Lord thus threatens such shepherds, through whom the Lord's sheep are neglected and perish, what else does it behoove us to do, dearest brother, than to exhibit full diligence for gathering and fostering the sheep of Christ, and to apply the medicine of paternal love for healing the wounds of the lapsed — since the Lord also admonishes in the gospel and says: *The healthy have no need of a physician, but they that are sick?* For although we shepherds are many, yet we feed one flock, and we ought to gather and to foster all the sheep which Christ sought by his blood and his passion, and not to suffer our suppliant and grieving brethren to be cruelly despised and trodden down

by the proud presumption of certain persons — since it is written: *But that man who is contumacious, vaunting himself, shall in no wise prosper; who has enlarged his soul like hell*, and the Lord in the gospel blames and condemns all such, saying: *You are they who justify yourselves in the sight of men. But God knows your hearts, for that which is exalted among men is an abomination in the sight of God*. He says that those are execrable and detestable who please themselves, who, swollen and inflated, arrogantly assume something to themselves. And since Marcianus has begun to be of their number and, joining himself to Novatian, has stood forth as an adversary of mercy and of piety, let him not pronounce sentence, but receive it; nor let him act as though he himself had judged concerning the college of the priests, since he himself has been judged by all the priests.

5. For the glorious honour of our predecessors, the blessed martyrs Cornelius and Lucius, is to be preserved: whose memory, since we honour it, much more ought you, dearest brother, to honour and to preserve it by your gravity and authority — you who have been made their vicar and successor. For they, full of the Spirit of the Lord and established in glorious martyrdom, judged that peace ought to be given to the lapsed, and signified by their letters that, penance having been done, the fruit of communion and of peace ought not to be denied. This thing we all, absolutely, everywhere have decreed. For there could not be among us a diverse opinion, in whom there was one Spirit: and therefore it is manifest that he does not hold the truth of the Holy Spirit along with the rest whom we see to hold a diverse opinion. Signify plainly to us who has been substituted at Arles in the place of Marcianus, that we may know to whom to direct our brethren and to whom we ought to write. I desire you, dearest brother, ever to fare well.

Ep. 69, § 5 — while the true shepherd remains (c. 255; pp. 753–754)

And therefore the Lord, insinuating to us the unity coming from the divine authority, lays it down and says: *I and the Father are one*. Reducing his Church to which unity, he says again: *And there shall be one flock and one shepherd*. But if there is one flock, how can he be numbered among the flock who is not in the number of the flock? Or how can he be held to be a shepherd who — while the true shepherd remains and presides in the Church of God by a successive ordination — succeeding no one, and beginning from himself, becomes an alien and a profane person, an enemy of the Lord's peace and of the divine unity, not dwelling in the house of God, that is, in the Church of God, in which none but the concordant and the unanimous dwell, the Holy Spirit speaking in the Psalms and saying: *God, who makes those of one mind to dwell in a house?* Finally, the Lord's sacrifices themselves also declare the Christian unanimity, bound together by a firm and inseparable charity. For when the Lord calls his body bread, compacted from the union of many grains, he indicates our people, whom he bore, made one; and when he calls his blood wine, pressed out from many clusters and grapes and gathered into one, he likewise signifies our flock, coupled together by the commingling of a united multitude. If Novatian is united to this bread of the Lord, if he too is commingled with the cup of Christ, he might be seen to be able also to have the grace of the one ecclesiastical baptism, if it be established that he holds the unity of the Church.